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Alien Humanoid or Earthly Fetus?

**Birth-Trauma
UFO Abductions
Debunked...page 4**



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EDITORIAL

A Crackpot Enterprise

If one were to take seriously the charges of ufology's critics, one would believe that UFO proponents are one or more of the following:

(1) *De facto Soviet agents.* One prominent UFO debunker has charged that those ufologists who contend the U.S. government has not told everything it knows about UFOs are serving the ends of the Soviet Union, which also seeks to undermine faith in our institutions. The debunker argues that only persons of uncertain patriotism think high-ranking officials sometimes lie.

(2) *Members of a radical antiscience cult.* If you have always thought (as I always have) that the average ufologist is a middle-aged Republican, you may wonder how one sharp-eyed debunker (who professes to believe ufology is a "reaction against science and reason") managed to pierce the ufologist's veneer of conservative conventionality. The answer? He did it by labeling as a "ufologist" a self-styled witch who admits that "emotionally," she distrusts science and technology and by asserting that her views are typical of ufologists. In a letter to me the woman, a respected reporter for National Public Radio, states emphatically, "I have *never* considered myself a ufologist...[The debunker] has obviously taken what I said totally out of context, deciding to use me as a 'ufologist' because I talk about a Luddite dimension to my feelings, without (I might add) also saying that I intellectually support much of scientific inquiry." Of course it's always possible that National Public Radio is a radical antiscience cult.

(3) *Cryptofascists who menace Western civilization.* UFO groups, one debunker writes, "are all too reminiscent of the bizarre irrational...cults which preceded the fall of democratic Germany in the 1920s."

(4) *Ambulatory schizophrenics.* Believers in UFOs and other anomalies, a debunker has suggested, may be "afflicted with a thought disorder that manifests in, among other possible symptoms, a faulty sense of reality...It is my opinion that much of the irrational behavior of many paranormalists may be more compatible with a diagnosis of ambulatory schizophrenia (or a close cousin thereof) than with mere naivete."

(5) *Money-grubbing exploiters out to bilk a gullible public.* To call them "UFO proponents" is to grant them an integrity and a seriousness of purpose they don't deserve; they are really "UFO promoters" who, possessing the sincerity of carnival hucksters, are fully aware that what they're selling is bogus.

In the face of such colorful departures from mundane reality, one can only wonder why UFO debunkers have chosen to make debunking (a perfectly respectable exercise in itself; after all, there is much that is debunkable about UFO claims) take on the appearance of a crackpot enterprise. Of course, rational critics do exist, but they operate from the self-evident premise that, in the words of prominent skeptic Daniel Cohen, "There is room for honorable men and women to disagree about the subject of UFOs." In other words, you don't have to be crazy, fanatical, crooked or subversive to think that possibly, behind all those sightings by trained observers and sophisticated tracking instruments, there is something interesting, maybe even something science doesn't know about yet. In fact, according to various polls on the subject, an educated person is more likely to come to that conclusion than not.

LETTERS

It says something about the sad state of UFO debunking that the best skeptical work, *The UFO Handbook* (1979)—no other even comes close to it—was written by former CUFOS staffer Allan Hendry, who is essentially a UFO proponent (and, incidentally, a vocal nonadmirer of the debunking fraternity). It also says something about which camp, the ufologists or the debunkers, has a greater claim to scientific seriousness. One characteristic of science is that it engages in self-scrutiny and internal criticism. Ufology, whatever its other faults (and it has plenty of them), does not hesitate to criticize itself; anyone who doubts this needs only to read the pages that follow.

Where debunkers are concerned, however, internal criticism is all but nonexistent. Several years ago ufologist Don Schmitt asked three leading debunkers if they could provide instances of internal criticism within the debunking camp. None was able to cite a significant instance and one even found the whole concept "strange." None of them, incidentally, has ever sought to disassociate himself from the irresponsible charges his colleagues have hurled at ufologists. To the contrary, debunkers invariably close ranks when challenged by proponents, each defending the others' right to irrational excess. Evidently the purpose of the debunking movement is to hunt heresies and beat them to death, not simply to seek out facts and draw rational conclusions from them. (We can all be grateful that it is no longer fashionable to burn heretics at the stake.) To crusaders, facts—defined as those things one uncovers through the dispassionate weighing of data and evidence—are really beside the point if they fail to support predetermined beliefs and apocalyptic pronouncements. To crusaders, the truth is greater than the sum of its facts.

That explains, of course, why the UFO-debunking literature is not very good, why little of it is taken seriously even by the most cautious UFO proponents. Yet debunking's failure is ufology's loss; a field so beset with difficulties and ambiguities (not to mention uncritical advocates) as UFO inquiry can only profit from reasonable critics, as (for example) parapsychology has profited from the insights of sane skeptics such as Ray Hyman, Marcello Truzzi, Susan Blackmore and the late Piet Hein Hoebens.

The one interesting figure in the debunking camp is James Oberg, who in the past has committed his share of rhetorical excesses but who has also produced solid critical analyses—respected by all serious ufologists—on bogus astronaut and Soviet sightings. For the most part Oberg has conducted himself with civility and restraint in his dealings with ufologists; in his interpretation of UFO cases he has investigated, reasoned argument takes precedence over polemics. Unfortunately, his continuing alliance with extremist colleagues, to whom he remains bound by professional and personal ties, causes him to be linked, if only by association, with the most notorious aspects of UFO- and ufologist-bashing.

In his best moments Oberg is a skeptic, not a debunker. A skeptic, says sociologist of science Marcello Truzzi, doubts; a debunker denies. "Skepticism," Belgian biologist Bernard Heuvelmans writes in a recent issue of *Cryptozoology*, "sums up the true spirit of scientific research. And it is precisely because this word has so much poise that it is deliberately or unconsciously used in a false, improper, or incorrect sense by most people, and particularly by those who could be branded as 'systematic debunkers.' When confronted with new facts or ideas...they simply shrug and say that, being skeptics, they cannot believe such fantastic tales. But they are not skeptics at all: they are just being incredulous, which is quite different. The essence of skepticism is doubt. To be a true skeptic, one has to doubt everything, even whether one's doubts are well-grounded..."

It is surely not unreasonable to argue that (whatever its ultimate cause) a strangely persistent phenomenon which has been widely reported by all sorts of people in all sorts of cultural contexts is worth attention. One does not even have to be a "believer" to acknowledge that UFOs are a mystery—of human psychology if nothing else. Surely whatever UFOs turn out to be, they have something to teach us. If science is not served by the pursuit of knowledge—even of phenomena with elements that seem peculiar and exotic to us in our present state of ignorance—then "science" exists only as a rhetorical fiction to be used by blustering polemicists who would rather ridicule than think. — Jerome Clark. ■

To the editor:

The Center for Identified Flying Objects (CIFOS) was recently established to study the psychological and sociological aspects of UFO and IFO observations.

CIFOS believes that UFOs can be studied only in relation to IFOs. For example, it is widely believed by UFO researchers that UFOs have stalled automobile engines. But is this true? Apparently no one, including Allan Hendry, has studied IFOs to determine if they allegedly have caused this type of power failure. CIFOS was thus established to study the similarities and differences between UFOs and IFOs and to investigate the reliability of testimony of UFO and IFO observers.

In order for CIFOS to study UFO and IFO incidents, individual IFO sighting reports and UFO hoaxes are needed. These reports apparently are not collected and studied by existing UFO organizations. So CIFOS is seeking the assistance of UFO investigators working for various UFO organizations. If you have (or will receive) IFO-sighting reports, CIFOS would like to hear from you. Please contact me at the address below for brief questionnaires which seek information about individual IFO incidents.

Eventually CIFOS will publish a catalog of IFO-sighting summaries for use by researchers.

Hobart Gregory Baker
Director, CIFOS
113 East Northwood Avenue
Columbus, Ohio 43201

To the editor:

In his response (*IUR*, January-February) to criticisms of his review of my and Ian Summers' skeptical book on cattle mutilations, *Mute Evidence*, Mark Chesney notes that no mutilologists have been able to refute us in open debate. I will go on record saying that I will meet any mutilologist, anytime, anywhere, to hold a public debate on the subject.

Daniel Kagan
New York City

Birth Traumas From Outer Space

by D. Scott Rogo

Editor's Note: In the last issue of IUR (March-April) D. Scott Rogo argued that serious methodological flaws in Alvin Lawson and William McCall's experiments with "imaginary abductions" rendered scientifically dubious their conclusions that such narratives are indistinguishable from "real" abduction stories. "So far," he wrote, "no objective test of this theory has been forthcoming—at least no test...that specifically restricted the experimenter's own bias."

It should be clear by now, I think, that Dr. Lawson is in no position to suggest a theoretical model about UFO abduction experiences based on such possibly spurious findings. Nevertheless, one far-reaching development that resulted from his research was the appearance of birth-memory models in ufology. This theory posits that UFO abductions are birth memories which, for some as-yet-unknown reason, are reexperienced later in life.

Lawson bases his theory on his perception that birth imagery crops up repeatedly in abduction accounts. Lawson also believes that the birth-memory theory can be tested in a number of ways—such as by determining whether all abduction reports already placed in the literature invariably contain birth imagery. He has also suggested that UFO abductees will report different types of alien experiences based on the kinds of births they underwent. He argues:

(1) *Birth imagery is self-evident in most abduction accounts.* Writing in the March 1985 issue of *Fate*, he cites the Betty Andreasson story as representative. (A full account of this incident appears in Raymond E. Fowler's *The Andreasson Affair* [1979].) Lawson observes that "Betty's abductors were typically fetal humanoids: short and frail with grayish skin, oversized heads and eyes and underdeveloped facial features. The richest birthlike event occurred in what Betty called the Cylindrical Room where she was enclosed in a clear plastic chair with a fitted cover which her captors filled with gray fluid. For a time she breathed through clear tubes which fit into her nostrils and mouth. She

reported that she could taste a pleasant substance and she felt relaxed and happy.

"This Cylindrical Room scene, only one of several such echoes in Betty's narrative, is obviously a return to the womb. The transparent chair in which she floated in fetal position suggests the amniotic sac; the gray fluid is the amniotic medium; the breathing and feeding tubes are the umbilical cord. Swallowing fluid is a common fetal event and pleasant and unpleasant taste sensations have been well documented."

He also notes that Betty spent much of her time during the abduction floating through tunnels, elevators and other "birth canal" passageways which lead to what he considers symbolic representations of amniotic chambers via cervical-type doorways. Lawson also argues that all abduction reports include such typical natal imagery.

(2) *Cesarean-born experimental subjects report abduction scenarios specifically devoid of critical birth imagery.* To prove his theory, Lawson (again in collaboration with W.C. McCall) conducted imaginary abduction sessions with eight cesarean-born subjects. He and McCall found that seven of these subjects reported no tunnel imagery, while an eighth subject offered a single questionable reference. Two additional subjects who claimed normal births reported tunnel imagery. Drawing on these findings, Lawson claims that he has obtained "statistical evidence" for his theory.

Before I go any further, let me point out that there are five major problems with Lawson's birth-memory theory, not to mention problems in the evidence he has collected in support of it. These problems are theoretical and empirical and they will be covered only briefly:

(a) *The birth-memory model is inconsistent with the UFO evidence in general.* There can be little doubt that the UFO phenomenon often displays evidence of a technological aspect. The evidence that some UFOs are

physical craft is impressive (see, for example, Jenny Randles' *UFO Reality: A Critical Look at the Physical Evidence* [1983]). Since the abduction phenomenon is linked phenomenologically to the UFO enigma, it is myopic to advance a theory about it that cannot account for all aspects of the more general mystery.

(b) *The birth-memory theory cannot explain several features of the abduction phenomenon.* Cases of mutual or even multiple abductions abound in the UFO literature. Lawson tries to skirt this issue by arguing that the witnesses in these cases usually describe "separate subjective experiences." They do not, he argues, describe concordant ones. This is not necessarily true, since some accounts containing unusual but mutually corroborating features can be found in the literature. (See, for instance, Jerome Clark's chapter "The Ultimate Alien Encounter" in my 1980 anthology *UFO Abductions*.)⁽¹⁾ But more important, Lawson's theory fails to explain what psychological factors could cause two or three persons to undergo "birth-memory" hallucinations at exactly the same time. This would be tantamount to two persons' suddenly undergoing a rare form of psychotic episode at precisely the same time, and for the same duration. This never occurs in clinical psychopathology.

(c) *The birth-memory theory is inconsistent with the very cases on which Lawson draws.* Special reference should be made here to the way Lawson presents the Andreasson case to support his views. He places great significance in the fact that the aliens she supposedly saw looked like embryos—clear evidence, in his mind, of birth imagery. But anyone familiar with the case will recall that these same aliens were seen by a second witness before the abduction took place. The father of the primary percipient saw the entities hopping across the lawn before he underwent a loss of consciousness. This must have been an awfully strange birth image!

(d) *The birth-memory theory is inconsistent with basic embryology.* Embryologists

today have a good working knowledge of exactly what an infant experiences during the birth process. The baby in no sense glides down a tunnel-like canal into the hands of welcoming figures. The infant would experience an unpleasant crushing, suffocating sensation while exiting from a totally dark environment out through the womb into a lighted area. The head of the child rests close to the opening of the cervix (i.e., a few inches), so the infant would not experience anything like a tunnel. The process of birth could be compared more to emerging from a tight cocoon than tunneling down a slip-and-slide.

Now would the infant have much conception of its own form because it takes time for the baby to develop any sense of body or ego boundaries. It could not even see very much since its visual apparatus isn't developed enough even to differentiate figures from a foreground.

(e) *Lawson's theory is inconsistent with the psychology of anomalous experience.* If birth-memory hallucinations rest at the core of the UFO abduction experience, then we would expect to find that similar syndromes occur in other psychological contexts as well. But they don't. The type of psychological syndrome about which Lawson is speculating is unheard of in psychology or psychiatry. Nor does this theory explain why the sighting of a UFO or flying object would be integral to the experience in the first place.

The birth-memory theory cannot surmount any of these five theoretical-empirical objections. But what is even worse, the critical and experimental evidence Lawson has collected for his theory is next to useless, for it is based on the same type of subjective judgment that destroyed the value of his work with imaginary-abduction reports.

To begin with, he never formally mapped out what should and should not be considered valid birth imagery before he undertook his survey of the literature. He seems merely to have read through several abduction accounts specifically looking for such imagery, then reported—out of context—anything that struck him as suspicious. This procedure allows just about anything to be considered a birth image according to Lawson's very loose and unstructured criteria. Critics of psychology are fond of poking fun at psychoanalysts' ability to detect sexual

imagery in every dream narrative they read. Lawson can be criticized on similar grounds.

All that he has proved is that, if you search hard and long enough, you are bound to find what you are looking for. I have already explained (March-April/UR) that the post-hoc and ad-hoc selection of data is an invalid procedure in science and psychology, so I will not further belabor the point. I would suggest, however, that anyone interested in Lawson's birth-memory theory should make a list of what should be considered unambiguous birth imagery. This list could then be given to an independent judge, along with a group of randomly selected UFO abduction reports. The number of birth images the judge finds could then be compared to the number of birth images to be found in a series of dream or guided-imagery protocols.⁽²⁾ This would allow the researcher to assess independently whether birth imagery really tends to occur in UFO abduction reports and whether it is any more common there than in any other mental-imagery exercise.

The test Lawson later designed to prove his theory is also highly questionable. This experiment relied on finding critical differences between the imaginary-abduction accounts of subjects who experienced normal births versus those delivered by cesarean section. While Lawson holds that the difference in content between these two subject populations serves as "statistical evidence" favoring his theory, this is decidedly not the case. There is no real evidence, to start with, that imaginary-abduction reports are indistinguishable from true-life accounts. So the claim that two groups of experimental subjects undergoing imaginary abductions may have varied their account based on their birth experiences is meaningless. Such a finding would have no bearing whatever on the nature of the "real-life" abduction experience.

But what is more important is that Lawson based his conclusions on a ridiculously small sample size. His conclusions rely on the reports of just 10 subjects, broken down into subgroups of eight and two persons respectively. No statistical test known to experimental psychology can be applied to such tiny subgroups. There is, therefore, no objective way to show that any difference between the groups resulted from anything other than coincidence.

There is another problem: the question of whether "tunnel" imagery is related to birth at all. Earlier I called this assumption into question. But I would also like to point out that tunnel imagery is an almost universal constituent of mental imagery in general. It appears in drug hallucinations, in out-of-body experiences, during meditation and as a result of biofeedback training in theta brain-wave production. Tunnel imagery is reported in such a wide variety of contexts, in fact, that some researchers believe these images to be physiological responses to altered states of consciousness; in other words, they may well have nothing to do with birth imagery at all. (For more information, see Kevin Drab's survey "The Tunnel Experience: Reality or Hallucination?" in the December 1981 issue of *Anabiosis: The Journal of Death and Dying*.)⁽³⁾

It seems evident that no real evidence has ever been collected to support Lawson's birth-memory theory. While he has perhaps collected enough observations to propose a birth-memory theory, so far he has not tested this hypothesis in any manner that would be convincing to the experimental scientist.

Finally, something should be said about Lawson's repeated allegation that the ufological community has unjustly ignored his evidence and ideas. This has happened, he would have us believe, because ufologists are emotionally tied to the extraterrestrial

Continued on page 16

"No real evidence has been collected to support Lawson's birth memory theory..."

THE UFOLink FALLACY

Recent issues of *IUR* have reflected the controversy over the findings of Daniel Kagan and Ian Summers in *Mute Evidence* (1984), which was unflattering to "mutologists" and "ufologists" alike, and especially to those who uncritically link the two fields. Other UFOLinks asserted by various proponents for Bigfoot are creatures, psychic phenomena, odd features on the Moon or Mars, mysterious disappearances of ships and planes...the list goes on and on.

By coincidence, I had just read *Mute Evidence* as part of a self-education process on that subject when the controversy surfaced, including the pained outcries of the wounded proponents. Previously, I had done a limited-scope pilot study of my own. Based on a study of reports in the files of the International Fortean Organization and a survey of state agencies, I concluded that the "mutilation mystery" was greatly inflated and that sacrificial cults seemed to be involved in some of the authentic cases. (See *Zetetic Scholar*, No. 7, 1980.) The more extensive study by Kagan and Summers was not only skillful and perceptive but also devastating to the assumptions—and, more importantly, to the practitioners themselves—of "mutology." Plainly, it holds many important lessons for "ufology" if the correct conclusions are drawn from it.

Exactly parallel to the UFO mystery, the animal-mutilation mystery has been artificially inflated by the mutological counterpart of IFOs, careless newspaper reporting and inept investigations. That is the main conclusion of *Mute Evidence*. On the other hand, Mark Chesney has overstated the case (*IUR*, January-February) in concluding that the book "demonstrates" (read, "proves") that "all the 'mutilations' have prosaic explanations," and "that they have nothing to do with UFOs." This is a Logical Error of the Obverse Kind.

The authors conclude that there is a residual mutilations mystery and hypothesize (on the basis of some cited evidence) that cults of some kind are responsible. This remains a hypothesis until more firmly established. We don't yet know for certain that mutilations "have nothing to do with UFOs." Continued monitoring of new incidents and additional hypothesis-testing is desirable, especially since *Mute Evidence* is

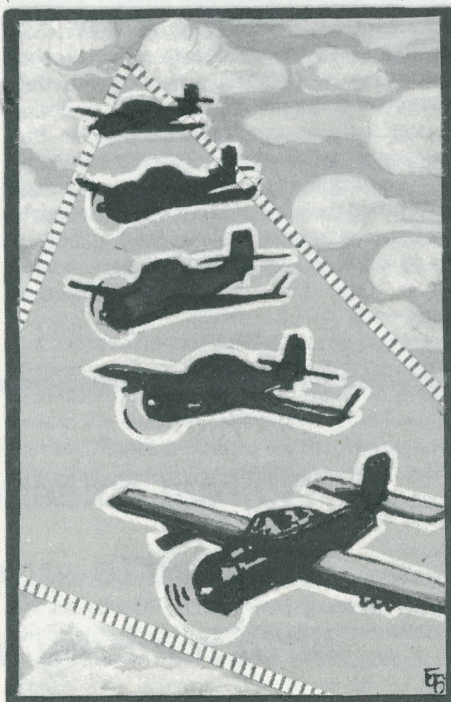
by Richard Hall

not a scientific work and overindulges in *ad hominem* attacks. Except for some cheap shots and some unfair generalizations, though, *Mute Evidence* is high-class "mutological" journalism. People of the authors' obvious skills and critical abilities would make good "ufologists."

What the book does is whittle the "mutilation mystery" down to size and show that the "experts" in that field have used inadequate methods and poor logic. It does what good peer review should do; too bad it wasn't written by "ufologists" when it comes to the alleged UFOLink. Fundamentally, the book demonstrates that "mute" proponents have failed to make a convincing case for a real mystery, much less for a UFOLink. The ball is in their court. They should heed the lessons, focus on truly puzzling cases and investigate them more thoroughly and critically.

Lessons for Ufology

To Kagan and Summers "mutology" is an offshoot or subcategory of "ufology," since they found the two fields commonly linked



together. We should all be aware by now that any alleged discipline that permits anyone to style himself as a qualified practitioner, with no prerequisite education, training or demonstrated critical abilities, falls far short of being a science. The very notion that persons otherwise not scientifically trained and applying themselves to a perceived mystery part-time should be considered "UFO scientists" is an absurdity. Until funds are available for rigorous scientific study, "ufology" is a pretentious concept that we would be better off without.

The UFO mystery—especially since it is largely ignored by science—affords an opportunity for people of many different backgrounds to make a contribution toward sensible study. But the involvement of real scientists and other professionals is imperative for this study to be truly scientific in spirit. Science is about objective appraisal of all relevant evidence, careful construction of hypotheses and constant cross-checking and testing of data and findings through peer group evaluations and other means.

What Kagan and Summers found behind the inflated mystery unfortunately applies to "ufology" as well and is the predictable result of the loose or nonexistent standards in the field—undisciplined, careless, egoistic practitioners who use distorted logic to grind various axes, desire to "be someone," and fail to understand the requirements of scientific method because of a predilection for a certain belief. Step right up, folks, anybody can be a scientist here! Obviously, not all "ufologists" fit this description, but all too many do. Nor has all "mutology" been that sloppy either, as the authors show.

If persons inexperienced in scientific methods would be "ufologists," they must learn not to assume *a priori* that a UFOLink exists, with mutilations, Bigfoot, the Bermuda Triangle or anything else. They must learn to be critical of their own assumptions, not merely cite selective data in an attempt to support what they already believe or think may be true. What you think may be true, after careful consideration of data, is a *hypothesis*. It is a starting point for investigation, not a scientific conclusion. Proponents of hypotheses must objectively consider arguments or evidence antithetical to their hypotheses.



A hypothesis is sort of a reverse question ("UFOs are extraterrestrial"/"Are UFOs extraterrestrial?"), and how questions are phrased is extremely important in science. The underlying questions before the hypothesis state are: "Is there a true UFO mystery reflected in the hard-core, unexplained cases? If so, what hypothetical explanations are there for the mystery?" A great deal of data gathering, critical thinking and objective analysis is necessary at the various levels of scientific method.

Many of us feel that the first-level question has been answered in the affirmative and we are now in the hypothesis-testing state. But we must always be aware that skeptics and uncommitted people may not have seen the same evidence or been exposed to the same logic and chain of reasoning. If we wish to persuade others to take UFOs seriously, it is incumbent upon us to present the evidence, logic and reason for why they should.

"Linkologists" as well as "ufologists" must, as a first order of business, determine the true parameters of the problem, weed out false and irrelevant material, compile carefully investigated case studies and demonstrate their case for a mystery. All of us need to present and reason from building-block cases that we feel represent a mystery. Excessive theorizing is a major curse of "ufology." ■

UFOs AND IFOs:

To the editor:

Jenny Randles' article "The Case Against the IFO" (*IUR*, January-February) discusses James Oberg's hypothesis that "all prime UFO cases are suspect as grossly exaggerated IFOs." She tested this hypothesis by analyzing the testimony of persons who observed a rocket reentry and who reported the rocket as a UFO. She concluded that all UFOs are not exaggerated IFOs. This conclusion, however, cannot be derived from the results she presented in her article; her conclusions are erroneous.

We must assume that, if all UFOs are really IFOs in disguise, a wide variety of objects, phenomena and events is responsible for triggering UFO reports. Randles assumes that a rocket reentry represents the variety of prosaic objects that are reported as UFOs. But since the stimuli are so varied and complex and so many variables affect IFO and UFO reports, Randles' conclusions are valid only for objects that behave like and resemble reentering rockets. Her conclusions cannot be extended to "UFOs" that are really airplanes, planets, hoaxes and so on.

Randles says that the rocket observers were "remarkably accurate." Yes, but not accurate enough.

For example, if observers are 99 percent accurate about the dates, times and locations of IFO sightings and also about the positions of IFOs in the sky, then probably at least 3 percent of IFOs will be unidentified! But controlled experiments strongly suggest that observers are much less than 99 percent accurate.

Randles states that the absence of "exotic" reports (CE2- and CE3-like reports) from the persons who observed the rocket reentry does not support the hypothesis that "all UFOs are exaggerated IFOs." Yet Allan Hendry's findings (*The UFO Handbook* [1979]), for example, revealed that Venus has triggered CE3 reports. A host of other prosaic objects have been responsible for triggering CE2 reports. In at least one instance, an airplane thought to be a UFO was reported to have

stalled an automobile (*Skeptical Inquirer*, Vol. 9, No. 3). Such reports must be considered to be examples of gross distortions of testimony and erroneous cause-and-effect relationships.

Another major problem with Randles' argument is that all of the "UFO" sightings she studied had a known cause (a rocket reentry). In the real world various objects cannot possibly be identified, since they have too many origins. Also UFO hoaxes exist in the real world. Randles' results and conclusions do not consider the consequences of these variables.

Oberg's hypothesis can be tested only by analyzing a large, representative sample of IFO reports (such as Hendry did) and by consulting the scientific literature for controlled experiments on the reliability of eyewitness testimony. The Center for Identified Flying Object Studies, which I direct, is attempting to test Oberg's hypothesis by acceptable scientific procedures.

In summary: (1) Randles' conclusions cannot be generalized and (2) more extensive studies do not support her conclusions. Thus, Oberg's hypothesis is still undisputed. As long as observers are less than 100 percent accurate and truthful, we have no uncontested "case against the IFO."

Hobart Gregory Baker
Columbus, Ohio

To the editor:

My compliments to Jenny Randles for her scientific attempt to use the reentry of the rocket-booster from Cosmos-1068, on December 31, 1978, to try to assess the accuracy of eyewitness accounts as applied to UFO reports. Were she to examine the nearly 100 reports received by the U.S. Air Force following the colorful reentry of another Soviet rocket, on the night of March

continued...

An Exchange

3, 1968, seen by many observers in the eastern United States, Randles would find a striking similarity.

For example, most observers concluded that what they had seen was a reentering satellite or a meteor-fireball. But for a few whose minds played tricks on them, the flaming debris seemed to be windows in what they described as a large saucer- or cigar-shaped craft. (See Chapter 1 of my *UFOs Explained* [1974].)

Estimates of the time duration showed greater disparity. For example, 15 percent of the observers estimated the duration at less

than 15 seconds, while 8 percent estimated the duration at more than five minutes. Randles reports that 3 percent of her eyewitnesses estimated the time duration at 10 minutes—clearly a gross exaggeration, as she points out.

When there are many dozens, or hundreds, or eyewitnesses to even a somewhat rare, short-lived incident, as with Zond-4 and Cosmos-1068, it is possible to analyze the many reports and come up with a reasonable "centroid" account and to disregard the grossly inaccurate extremes.

But suppose that Cosmos-1068's rocket had reentered over the mid-Pacific after mid-

night, where it had been seen only by a single observer, say the helmsman of a merchant ship. Suppose that this lone observer had estimated the time duration at 10 minutes and that his mind had "filled in the nonexistent body," so it became a giant craft with illuminated windows.

For many ufologists his report would seem to constitute a "True UFO" and any effort to explain it as a rocket reentry would be rejected. There are important lessons to be drawn from Randles' experiment—although perhaps not the ones that she prefers, or intended.

Philip J. Klass
Washington, D.C.

Jenny Randles Replies:

I go along with Klass' and Baker's arguments about 90 percent of the way. Beyond that, I am not convinced that they have tackled the essential issues I sought to raise in my article.

I see no evidence, for one thing, that media promotion or social pressures seriously generate UFO data. The Spielberg "climate" and New Zealand film publicity hype were key factors in the Cosmos-1068 affair in Britain. If all UFOs are IFOs (in various degrees of exaggeration), then common sense suggests that UFO reports ought to be more widespread at times of such promotion. But it just is not so.

British UFO Research Association (BUFORA) and Northern UFO Network (NUFON) case files (on independent sets of data) both show that 1978 (the year *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* was released in Britain) was not an atypical one. In 1977 a huge wave of sightings had occurred—before the film; 1979 was lower than usual. In 1978 virtually every media outlet in the United Kingdom shoved UFOs down people's throats, the bookstores were choked with a few good books and a tidal wave of trash, and one paper (London's *Daily Express*) even ran a "UFO Bureau" for two weeks and had toll-free lines and other inducements to encourage reporting. It got plenty of reports—a couple of thousand of them, in fact. But nearly all of them were old ones, never before

reported. This onslaught did not turn 1978 into a wave year.

I would like to point out that my book *UFO Reality* (1983) is 250 pages long and the Cosmos-1068 study comprises just half a dozen pages in it. The rest of the book anticipated and responded to almost all the points made by Klass and Baker. For example, on page 48, I wrote, "If we take an isolated report from the Cosmos-1068 data, could we trace it to the original source? Bear in mind that in most UFO reports there are not hundreds of supporting witnesses, so we are dealing with an isolated instance. I think it is fair to say that this would have been possible, and this gives impressive evidence that UFO accounts are, in most cases, reasonably close to the initial stimulus. But this evidence does not prove the point. Perhaps all close encounters are gross exaggerations."

Although I explained in the next 200 pages why I did not think they were, this position remains the only honest one.

I went on immediately to consider the way persons such as Vallee, Hendry and Merritt had used IFO versus UFO statistics (e.g., on the duration of events) to try to show that the two were separate phenomena. I cautioned, however (page 49), "I feel [the apparent differences] have something to do with the fact that UFOs, if they are all reducible to IFOs, would be a mixture of many phenomena

which would peak at *different* durations." (For instance, meteors have an average life many orders of magnitude less than balloons and so any set of data that include mixtures of these and many other phenomena is going to have a seemingly hybrid "duration" which will not resemble the individual durations of any one IFO phenomenon.)

Over the years of my investigation, even before Allan Hendry's epic work stimulated me further, I have held to the belief that IFO study is too often overlooked. I have discussed many IFO incidents in my books. For instance, in *UFO Reality* (pages 39-42) I describe a Lincolnshire incident in which three witnesses in a car were scared out of their wits by a strange "object" which chased them across the countryside. The witnesses followed the classic Hynek "escalation-of-hypotheses" principle, at first assuming they were seeing a hovering Harrier jet and settling on the UFO identification later.

The local investigator, although he produced a good case report, did not explain the sighting. I was fortunate enough to be able to do so, due to several factors. What the witnesses had seen (and invested with an outline shape) was one star and a planet in coincidental formation against a sky with thinly-veiled cloud. The psychological trauma of the chase and the investing of the astronomical phenomenon with "life" compounded the error and produced the encounter.

I was able to explain the sighting because of:

(1) An excellent case report which gave all the necessary data for correct evaluation (even though the investigator had not done so).

(2) A generally accurate perception of the phenomena by the witnesses. Yes, they had exaggerated. I never doubt that this always happens. But, as in the Cosmos cases, the exaggeration did not distort the evidence sufficiently to prevent evaluation.

(3) A coincidental previous report in which the investigator *had* identified the stimulus in a very similar way.

All of these factors are crucial and they taught me vital lessons which I have used in the development of British investigation teams which I have the privilege to supervise. I think the lessons could be applied more widely.

For instance, the need for detailed case reports containing all relevant data is paramount. If investigators who know what they are doing ask the right questions early enough of a witness and then include all the important associated data (e.g., weather readings, description of geographical environment, social background of witnesses, belief systems), a properly experienced evaluator can usually identify a case when an identification is feasible. Such evaluations, however, require the evaluator also knows what he is doing. It is essential that he be familiar with previous IFO cases so that he can go back and search out (through association or society files that are organized enough to make these quickly retrievable) any relevant past cases. There really is no other way of spotting what I call the "telltale signs" for one of the more obscure identifications which this particular case *might* be.

Here in Britain we have worked hard to get a system like this functional. So long as the investigators do their stuff and we can rely upon the general accuracy of the main facets of a witness' report (these decay rapidly with the length of time between event and interview), then *if* a case is evaluated "unknown," I feel reasonably inclined to believe that it probably is *not* reducible to an IFO.

Of course there will be cases in which the witness has grossly exaggerated to the point that the UFO label gets falsely attached, even after evaluation. There are some hoaxes and

hallucinations, too. But I see no evidence whatever that these three cautions account for anything like the deluge of unexplained cases, well investigated and written up by experienced investigators.

Interestingly enough, we have found that tightening standards of investigation and evaluation, coupled with the dearth of case reports in the wake of *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*, has produced an effect we could not have predicted. The percentage of unknowns and of close-encounter cases in our data has risen markedly. We are getting fewer cases and weeding out the flimsy ones more quickly but we are ending up with many more truly puzzling reports in consequence.

Most of *UFO Reality* is built around a detailed study of 1,051 cases for the period 1975-1979, collated, investigated and evaluated as above, but also evaluated by me. This "JR Set," as I call it, is set out chapter by chapter according to features (psychological effects, physiological effects, trace cases, car-stops, radar-visuals, etc.). Each chapter includes IFOs from the set to demonstrate the similarities and differences. A matrix system for plotting data is used and a vast amount of material is thus presented in tabular form throughout the book. A case was evaluated as unknown only if the investigator so concluded *and* I concurred and if it reached Level B on a scale of investigation which I use. *To reach Level B the case must at least be a combination of written data, eye-to-eye interview of witnesses, and an accompanying case report provided, i.e., not simply witness statements but real investigative work.*

I rated as unknown 14.8 percent of the JR Set and there were 35 different categories of IFO (full table on page 26). These including strange things like sunspots, insect swarms, model aircraft and a dog! This level was higher than the one Hendry found. In *UFO Handbook*, upon which my study was partly based, I noted that Hendry had rated only 9.6

percent of his cases as "close encounters," this on the Hynek definition of a close encounter which might be only by virtue of the distance guessed by the witness. My definition of "close encounter" is more strict; see the revised classification scheme Peter Warrington and I developed in our *UFOs: A British Viewpoint* (1979).

For me a close encounter *must* include associated effects of one kind or another (car-stops, animal disturbance, physiological effects). Even so, 13.1 percent of the JR Set met those criteria—which is probably due to the difference in investigative techniques more than anything; we tend not to pursue obvious IFOs which offer no instructive data.

Of course, there *were* IFO cases including close-encounter effects, just as Hendry had found—but very few of them. There was a clear gulf, in my estimation, between the degree of exaggeration in these proven IFO cases and the degree necessary *if* the apparent UFO close encounters were also to be rated as IFOs. Generally, this would require calling into question the psychological state or mental health of the witness.

I might note here that hoaxes in the JR Set were found to be at only 1.6 percent and those with pathological factors were even less. I have not noticed any other set of figures (from UFO proponent or skeptic) which seriously contradicts such levels. They are *not* significant facets in the UFO/IFO question.

Of course, the skeptics argue that the grossly exaggerated IFOs, masquerading as IFOs in our data, do so because there are far more psychopathological witnesses than we have recognized. Okay—but where's the evidence? Psychologists who have studied UFO data almost always come away concluding that witnesses are mostly normal people. In Britain we are involved in a project hoping to produce hard evidence bearing on this question.

Initiated by Dr. Alexander Keul at Salzburg University, this psychological study is being supervised for us by Ken Phillips, an experienced investigator who now serves as BUFORA's investigatory training officer. He is willing to share results, questionnaires and other data with any bona-fide investigator or group that wants to join in what is called the "Anamnesis Project" (Phillips can be contacted at 13

**"A close encounter
must include associated
effects of one kind or
another."**

Continued on page 15

THE SOUTHWESTERN LIGHTS

Part One

by Brad Sparks and Jerome Clark

On December 5, 1948, a clear Sunday night, the pilot and copilot of an Air Force C-47 en route from Denver to Phoenix saw something that would set in motion one of the strangest series of events in UFO history. But the man who first witnessed the phenomenon, Capt. William Goade, had no inkling of what was to come in the days and weeks to follow. In fact, initially he was not even sure he had seen anything out of the ordinary.

At 9:05 p.m. Goade spotted a bright green flash just west of Las Vegas, New Mexico. He assumed it was a meteor and forgot about it. He remembered it, however, when he saw the same thing 22 minutes later as his C-47 passed some 20 miles northeast of Albuquerque. This time he and his copilot, Maj. Roger Carter, got a good—if brief—look at it.

Goade, who saw it longer, watched an intense green light rise from the east slope of Sandia Park a few miles away. The object was following a parabolic curve. Goade, a combat veteran, thought this was the weirdest "flare" he had ever seen. Carter, who had it in view for no more than one or two seconds, saw it as a motionless greenish-blue light growing in intensity, then suddenly fading.

The two men talked about the sighting for a few minutes and decided to report it to the control tower at Kirtland Air Force Base, Albuquerque. Control personnel were sufficiently impressed with the account that an hour and a half later, when a Pioneer Airlines flight landed in Albuquerque, they asked crew members if they had seen anything unusual near Las Vegas, New Mexico.

The pilot and copilot reported they had seen it as they were heading west toward Las Vegas at about 9:35—a bright green light which the pilot initially took to be a meteor. But now he wasn't so sure—it seemed to have been too close to the ground.

A little later the airline captain phoned Kirtland tower to supply more details. He said he had been hesitant to report the sighting

because such matters "generally are not accepted." The pale green light had come straight at him, he said, and he had swerved the plane to avoid hitting it. The light and its pale green trail curved downward and vanished after a few seconds.

The next day, when Kirtland's security officer called the Air Force Office of Special Investigations (AFCSI) to report the incidents, Lt. Col. Doyle Rees, commander of the 17th District AFCSI office based at Kirtland, ordered his agents to investigate. AFCSI was responsible for all investigations of espionage, sabotage and criminal activity within the Air Force. The fireballs might represent sabotage activity.

On December 8 they talked with the New Mexico State Police, the U.S. Forest Service, the Civil Aeronautics Administration aircraft controllers and private operators at the airport in Las Vegas, and the Las Vegas police chief. None of them knew anything about the green "flare" incidents.

The AFCSI men asked the local agencies to contact them if they heard of any such incidents in the future. They impressed upon CAA personnel the "highly classified" nature of such information. Determined to keep publicity about their investigation to a minimum, they did not even contact the local newspaper for information.

This accomplished, AFCSI agents Capt. Melvin Neef and John Stahl checked out the terrain where the sightings had been made. At 6:33 that evening they were airborne about 20 miles east of Las Vegas when, incredibly enough, they saw a green fireball. The object, considerably brighter than a meteor or a flare, suddenly burst into view and flashed toward and just above them to the left at their 11 o'clock position. It seemed to hold an almost flat trajectory parallel to the earth for about two seconds, then suddenly dropped downward and turned into a trail of reddish-orange sparks which vanished in less than a second.

AFCSI began to take the green-fireball reports very seriously.

As word of the incidents got out, witnesses came forward to describe their own experiences. The first of these was Army Col. William Hayes, who was stationed at Kirtland. Hayes had seen mysterious fireballs on three occasions, most recently on November 23. In each case the colonel had been driving near Vaughn, New Mexico, at about 10:00 p.m. and had observed an extremely bright white basketball-sized object coming straight down. Each time it exploded silently into fiery red fragments which extinguished before touching the ground.

On the afternoon of December 9 AFCSI agent Neef interviewed Dr. Lincoln La Paz, director of the Institute of Meteoritics at the University of New Mexico in Albuquerque. Neef described all of the sightings, including his own, to the mathematician-astronomer, who held a Top Secret clearance. La Paz said the objects in question did not sound at all like meteors and should be investigated thoroughly.

To be sure, La Paz later reviewed his records of the Geminid meteor shower, which was prominent at that time of year, but could find no record of any green color associated with it. He had personally witnessed 414 Geminid meteors since 1915 and not one had been green.

La Paz knew of three other unexplained fireball cases from 1948, including one near the Hanford nuclear facility in Washington state and another near Memphis, the opposite end of Tennessee from the vital Oak Ridge uranium enrichment facility.

Early that evening (December 9) agent Stahl flew over the site of his observation the night before but saw nothing unusual.

On Saturday, the 11th, Col. Rees called a conference to discuss the situation. AFCSI

had learned of another sighting, this one at the supersecret Sandia base at Albuquerque, where all of the nation's nuclear weapons were built. At 10:55 p.m. that Monday, Atomic Energy Security Service (AESS) officer Joseph Toulouse, waiting at a stop sign on the base, saw a "greenish flare" out of the right-hand corner of his windshield. The "flare," fully one-third the apparent size of the moon, developed a "flaming tail" just before it arched downward slightly and disappeared. It had been visible for a maximum of three seconds.

What was going on? Was somebody or something developing an unhealthy interest in America's nuclear facilities? The Hanford incident. The Memphis sighting (though that may have been stretching the point; at that moment its only connection with Oak Ridge was the same state). But the Sandia connection was real enough to make the security agencies in New Mexico nervous. They wondered if a pattern—an ominous pattern—was starting to develop.

The green UFOs seemed to be just one step behind the investigators. At 9:02 p.m. on December 12 La Paz had his own sighting as he and two Civil Air Patrol men were driving near Bernal, New Mexico. An expert meteor observer, La Paz noticed it first and shouted "Look!" four times order to establish the time frame for subsequent reenactments of the event.

As bright as Venus and about one-fourth the Moon's diameter, the green ball was traveling east to west low over the horizon. La Paz later stressed that it stayed horizontal for most of the 2.2 seconds it was in view, curving downward only during the last two-tenths of a second when it broke and vanished.

By a stroke of luck two AESS inspectors also witnessed the fireball and La Paz was able to triangulate its location and altitude and obtain a rough estimate of its speed.

When plotted on a map, the 25-mile east-to-west path pointed away from the Los Alamos Scientific Laboratory, the location of all United States nuclear-weapons-design work. The object, in other words, might have flown directly over Los Alamos.

But most astonishing of all was the fact that the object had maintained a *horizontal path at an altitude of about eight to ten miles*—deep in the earth's atmosphere. Most meteors burn up above 40 miles, La Paz

noted. It was inconceivable that a meteor could survive at such a low altitude, let alone keep from falling. (While meteorites can be seen at lower altitudes and can survive to strike the ground, they make a tremendous roar as they pass through the dense layers of atmosphere.) Moreover, the estimated speed, eight to ten miles per second (29,000 to 43,000 mph), was incredibly slow for meteors, with typical speeds of about 30 or 40 miles per second, but fantastically beyond the capability of aircraft and rockets. Only certain shaped-charge experiments during rocket flights had come close at that time.

In his report to AFCSI the next day, La Paz said, "I am now convinced the various 'green flare' incidents...are not meteoric in nature."

While Col. Rees contacted AFCSI Headquarters for advice on immediate action, La Paz prepared a study of the incidents for the colonel. While previously-unreported incidents from the nights of December 5, 6, and 7 streamed in, new sightings occurred on the 13th and 14th.

La Paz arranged with the AESS to set up a patrol with Speed Graphic cameras to try to photograph the fireballs. The patrol caught a normal meteor on the 18th and nothing on the 19th. Late on the evening of December 20 members had just packed their cameras to go home when a green fireball appeared, so they missed getting a photograph of it. Fortunately, a triangulation was possible because several persons had carefully observed it from separate locations. La Paz was able to fix a short seven-to-eight mile west-to-east path for the UFO. The path headed straight toward Los Alamos.

At the Oak Ridge National Laboratory, although people were still unaware of the New Mexico sightings, rumors were flying. George D. Rathman, chief of the investigation section of the AESS at Oak Ridge, sent some photographs of an unusual contrail taken in

July 1947 by an Oak Ridge resident to the Project NEPA (Nuclear Energy Propulsion for Aircraft) Research Center at Oak Ridge. NEPA was the Air Materiel Command program for building the world's first nuclear-powered airplane (the project was canceled in 1961 without ever getting a prototype built).

Col. C. D. Gasser, who was in charge of the NEPA center, was intensely interested in UFOs. When Gasser and Rathman later learned that the photographer had passed around a number of prints to friends, Gasser became quite concerned and insisted that publicity be kept to a minimum. Gasser had Rathman gather up as many of these prints as he could get his hands on so that they could be sent to the Air Force. A month later Project Sign, the Air Force UFO project, reported anticlimactically that the pictures were the product of a simple defect in the negatives.

Gasser did not yet know what the Sign conclusions would be when he supplied prints of the photographs to the Knoxville FBI office in early January 1949. He told the FBI that Air Force Intelligence officials believed the "mystery missiles" (UFOs) were "man-made" objects, not natural phenomena. The Air Force had compiled a "great deal of information" on them and conducted "extensive" research to find out "whether or not an adequate defense can be established." The military was keeping a lid on all this and even Gasser had not been entrusted with "all information pertaining to the missile."

Nevertheless, in a sort of personal intelligence-gathering operation, Gasser thought he had pieced together enough information to figure out what was going on. He had read many of the sighting reports (NEPA was on the distribution list for Sign's reports) and talked with the people at Wright-Patterson Air Force Base. In fact, he claimed, these reports had given "impetus" to the

continued...

"The flare...developed a flaming tail just before it arched downward slightly and disappeared."

American development of nuclear propulsion for aircraft and guided missiles.

It was Gasser's private, confidential opinion that the "man-made" devices were Soviet nuclear-propelled missiles. Gasser apparently misunderstood Project Sign's use of the adjective "man-made," taking it to imply earthly origin when it really meant "artificial" and extraterrestrial.

Gasser claimed that it had been known since about 1944 or 1945 that the Soviets were experimenting with a "flying disc." CIA reports from agents in southern Europe and southern Asia alleged that the U.S.S.R. was testing a long-range, remotely-piloted aircraft or missile. Since the Soviets were developing nuclear energy, Gasser thought they might possibly have the capability to build reactors for use in aircraft propulsion.

As further "evidence" of Soviet origin, Gasser noted that, according to reports he had received, the "missiles" usually approached the United States from the north, cruised around, then headed back north over the pole. This thesis about the north-south paths was a distorted version of an idea proposed by Lincoln La Paz.

The FBI special agent in charge of the Knoxville office, C. C. McSwain, sent a lengthy report of Gasser's remarks to headquarters on January 10. Two weeks later D. Milton Ladd, assistant director for security, summarized them for J. Edgar Hoover.

On March 25, after the Air Force Office of Intelligence (AFOIN) had requested the FBI to forward any UFO reports it got, Hoover instructed his field office heads to comply, adding melodramatically that a "reliable and confidential source" (Gasser) had informed the Bureau that flying discs were Soviet vehicles—a frightening conclusion to draw at a time when Soviet belligerence was at a high, the Berlin airlift was in full swing and the Nationalist Chinese were retreating from the onslaught of Communist forces.

Similar rumors about Soviet devices were circulating throughout the Southwest. At the weekly Wednesday intelligence conferences of the 4th Army, AFCSI, Office of Naval Intelligence, and FBI in San Antonio, the numerous sightings of unexplained phenomena around Albuquerque and Los Alamos figured prominently in the discussions. In the excitement the intelligence men in San Antonio were unearthing every conceivable item of information, all of it considered Top

Secret by the alarmed Army and Air Force representatives. Later, when the panic had subsided a bit, the classification was revised to Secret.

The group talked about the 1946 Swedish ghost rockets which, it decided, "might have originated in Russia." It also heard a distorted version of La Paz's ideas. The New Mexico objects were said to travel on an east-west line "with the probability that they approach from the northern quadrant [whatever that means] which would be the last stage of the great circle route if they originated in Russia." This was dead wrong. Such a great-circle path would start in the south Indian Ocean nowhere near the Soviet Union.

Meanwhile, in New Mexico, security officials had been trying to handle the cases as routinely as possible so as not to give vent to a perhaps understandable impulse to panic. Very few cases came in during January—until the 30th, that is. Then all hell broke loose.

*"Hundreds of people
all over New Mexico,
west Texas and
southern Colorado
sighted a green
fireball...the
most spectacular."*

At 5:54 p.m. that Sunday afternoon hundreds of people all over New Mexico, west Texas and southern Colorado sighted a green fireball. It was far and away the most spectacular such incident reported then or for years thereafter.

Government officials moved fast. Dr. La Paz helped organize teams to interview witnesses and to use surveyor's instruments for precise reenactments. La Paz had many times been able to track the impact points of meteorites, even locating them on the ground. If there was a chance that the object, meteorite or not, could be found by these methods, the scientist did not want to pass it by.

In a priority classified message Kirtland's commanding officer, Col. Harold Gunn, told AFCSI Headquarters that he had begun an "all out investigation" in hopes of locating the strange fireball's impact point "if any." The AEC, Armed Forces Special Weapons Project (AFSWP, the military unit in charge of all American nuclear weapons), the Fourth Army and local commanders all were "perturbed by the implications" of the phenomenon, he stressed.

After interviewing dozens of persons over hundreds of miles, La Paz managed to get a rough triangulation and AFCSI agents and other military personnel spread out to try to recover fragments. A Roswell, New Mexico, AFCSI investigator who thought he had seen the object disintegrate near him provided a bum lead which wasted many hours in fruitless searching. Finally, when La Paz had gotten more reports and better fixes, the searchers moved into the area around Lamesa, Texas.

After days of mud-drenched searches and bone-rattling rides in jeeps, the investigators gave up. La Paz was thoroughly baffled. When meteorites fell, he could usually locate fragments with an adequate search party and good observations to guide him. Here he had practically the state of New Mexico and the United States government at his disposal, plus superb observations—and there was nothing.

La Paz plotted an incredible 143-mile-long path from Amarillo to Lamesa; this time it was a north-south track. The green fireball had followed a very nearly horizontal path, starting at about 60,000 feet altitude and ending at about 40,000 feet. The speed was estimated at between 25,000 and 50,000 mph. At that hypersonic speed and low altitude there should have been a tremendous sonic boom. *Yet there was no sound at all.*

What did it mean? La Paz suggested a possible answer to AFCSI agent Paul Ryan when the two talked in Roswell on February 6. Maybe the green fireballs were controlled missiles traveling around the earth at high speed. That would explain their nearly level trajectory at such low altitudes. Such a missile could be brought down to a designated target area and exploded by radio-equipped agents, La Paz suggested. Perhaps the Soviet Union or some other country was practicing with these weapons using only dummy warheads which could later be replaced with nuclear

"Worried nuclear agencies in New Mexico called a Conference on Aerial Phenomena."

warheads. The AFCSI later reported La Paz's words to the El Paso, Texas, FBI office.

The next day Dr. Joseph Kaplan, an expert geophysicist at UCLA and a member of the Air Force Scientific Advisory Board (AFSAB), lectured on the upper atmosphere at the University of New Mexico, probably at the request of La Paz, an old friend. Afterwards they met and La Paz detailed the recent green-fireball sightings. Kaplan was impressed and disturbed, all the more so when he further discussed the situation with Capt. Neef of AFCSI and Maj. William Godsoe, Fourth Army Intelligence liaison officer at the Sandia Base, both of whom were at the lecture.

Before he left, Kaplan said he believed the "probability of unimportance is vanishing." (In normal English that means, "The phenomenon is probably pretty important.") He promised to tell Dr. Theodore von Karman, world-renowned aerodynamicist and AFSAB chairman, that the green fireballs should be investigated in the name of national defense.

Worried nuclear agencies in New Mexico called a "Conference on Aerial Phenomena" at the Los Alamos Scientific Laboratory the afternoon of February 16. La Paz was there and so were representatives of AFCSI, AESS, AFSWP and the Fourth Army. A half-dozen lab officials, including Norris E. Bradbury and weapons-development director Edward Teller, also attended.

One agency *not* represented at the meeting, though it had promised to be there, was Project Sign. It no longer existed, at least by that name. On December 16 the new Air Force Director of Research and Development, Brig. Gen. Donald Putt, who had come over from the Air Materiel Command (AMC) engineering division and replaced Gen. Craigie in September 1948, decided to give

Sign only one more year of operation as a special high-priority project. And he wanted the name changed.

This abrupt change in attitude toward Sign and UFOs presaged an organizational shake-up and transfer of most of Sign's extraterrestrial advocates to other jobs at AMC. After scientists at the RAND Project and on the Air Force Scientific Advisory Board (AFSAB) had failed to back the outer-space conclusion, the AMC people had grown discouraged about the prospects of getting scientific substantiation for the Top Secret "Estimate of the Situation."

Project Sign was established in the AMC's T-2 division on January 22, 1948. Its personnel became convinced early on that UFOs were extraterrestrial vehicles, a conviction reinforced by a spectacular early-morning encounter over Alabama the following July 24, when two Eastern Airlines pilots reported seeing a large object with the fuselage of a B-29 and two rows of lighted "windows," with a 50-foot trail of orange-red flame streaming from the back. A maintenance crew chief at Robins AFB, Georgia, independently witnessed the event.

Impressed because this seemed to be the first reliable double-confirmation case, Sign prepared a thick Top Secret "Estimate of the Situation: Flying Discs" addressed to the Chief of Staff and detailing the project's astounding conclusions. The term "estimate of the situation" has nothing to do with intelligence, contrary to the mythology promoted in some UFO books. It is simply a term military commanders use to label their reports of battlefield situations—combat jargon, in other words. The AMC's flying-disc project fancied itself in command of a new battleground: space.

This explosive report passed through channels until it reached Chief of Staff Hoyt S. Vandenberg, who promptly defused it by rejecting its findings.

With the personnel turnover, the name of Sign was changed to Project Grudge on February 11, 1949, and the project adopted a policy of hostility toward UFOs, in accord with the new chill in Washington. (Later the personnel changeover was the excuse given for Grudge's not attending the Los Alamos conference.) Edward J. Ruppelt, who eventually headed Grudge, changed the name again because, as he would write in his *Report on Unidentified Flying Objects* (1956), "too

many people were guessing correctly what it meant."

Ruppelt remarked that after studying the UFO files he was so struck with the dramatic policy reversal that he, like so many others, wondered if there was a hidden reason for it. "Was it actually an attempt to go underground, to make the project more secretive?" he asked himself. "Was it an effort to hide the fact that UFOs were proven to be interplanetary and that this should be withheld from the public to prevent a mass panic?"

At the Los Alamos conference the participants were discussing the official attitudes. Major Godsoe said that except for the Air Force, "Most of the military [Army] authorities think we are crackpots." "We aren't laughing," responded Navy Cdr. Richard Mandelkorn of the AFSWP Research and Development Division at Sandia Base.

But the scientists needed heavy persuasion. La Paz detailed his arguments against meteors, adding that Kaplan had assured him that the fireballs were not part of some official "classified training exercise." La Paz noted that most observers had described a pale-green or yellow-green color rather than the meteoric *blue-green*. Such colors had never been reported with meteors, so far as La Paz could determine. A witness to one sighting himself, he said the color was rather like the flame spectra of copper.

One obvious objection to the meteor theory was that the fireballs had appeared in a sudden concentration and had been confined mostly to the Southwest. Good weather conditions in the Southwest couldn't explain it, either, because "this year the Eastern half of the country has offered phenomenal [good] observing conditions."

Finally the scientists reached a consensus that the phenomenon was real (many had seen it themselves) and that a network of instrument stations should be organized to photograph it and analyze it with technical devices.

Just before the meeting closed, Teller said that his calculations of the expected noise level of any material object with the green fireball's features suggested that it wasn't solid but an electro-optic phenomenon. *That*, Bradbury retorted, would be even more difficult to explain.

This is Part One of a three-part article.

Ballad of an 18th Century UFO

by Jerome Clark

Since the early years of the UFO age, flying saucers—as befits their place in popular culture—have occasionally been the subject of songs.

In the early 1950s, for example, the Buchanan Brothers, a hillbilly gospel duo, averred in their “When You See Those Flying Saucers” that UFOs were signs of Jesus’ imminent Second Coming. Billy Lee Riley’s 1957 hit “Flying Saucers Rock ‘n’ Roll” was a rip-snorting rockabilly rave-up. The Byrds’ mid-1960s “Mr. Spaceman” wed UFOs to psychedelic rock. My own favorite, though, is by an obscure singer-songwriter named Tom Pacheco, who on an (unfortunately long-out-of-print) RCA album, *The Outsider*, memorably performs his folk-rock composition “Judge Proctor’s Windmill,” a hilarious retelling of the famous (though, alas, untrue) story of the Martian airship that crashed in Aurora, Texas, in April 1897.

Recently, however, California folklorist Clark Branson has come upon the earliest known song about the sighting of a UFO. It appears in an 1867 work, *The Ballads and Songs of Derbyshire*, compiled by Llewellynn Jewitt. The book is a collection of old English broadside ballads, rhymes composed by songsmiths, sold by peddlers and intended to be sung to familiar melodies. Many of these dealt with topical matters, including political events, murders, wars and other subjects currently in the public eye. A few of these broadsides survived to enter (in altered form) oral tradition and become folk songs. But most were quickly forgotten, as was the case with one entitled “On the Strange and Wonderful Sight That Was Seen in the Air on the 6th of March 1716”:

*The sixth of March, kind neighbors this is true,
A wonder in the Sky came to my View;
I pray believe it, for I tell no Lye,
There’s many more did see it as well as I.*

*I was on a Travel, and was very late,
To speak the truth just about Day-light’s gate;
My Heart did tremble being all alone,
To see such Wonders—the like was never known.*

*The first of all so dark it was to me,
That much ado my Way I had to see;
I turn’d me round to see some Lights appear,
And then I saw those Wonders in the air.*

*These Lights to me like great long spears did show,
Sharp at one end, kind neighbors this is true;
I was so troubled I could not count them o’er,
But I suppose there was above a score.*

*Then I saw like Blood it did appear,
And that was very throng among those spears;
I thought the Sky would have opened in my View,
I was so daunted I knew not what to do.*

*The next I saw two Clouds meet fierce together
As if they would have fought one another;
And darkened all these Spears excepting one,
They gave a Clash and quickly they were gone.*

*The very last Day in the same month I am told
Many people did strange Sights behold;
At Hartington, the truth I will not spare,
That night they saw Great Wonders in the Air.*

*This Hartington it is in Darbyshire,
And credible persons living there,
They have declared that Wonders they did view
The very last night in March it’s certain true.*

*About Eleven a’Clock late in that Night,
A very dark Cloud which then did them sore afright;
Great smoke there came, it was perfect to their view,
They cried out, O Lord, what must we do?*

*They saw Great Lights which did amaze them sore,
The like was never seen in any Age before,
They went into their Houses for to Pray,
We must Repent whilst it is call’d to Day.*

Jewitt says that he found the ballad in a chapbook called “The Garland of Merriment,” printed in 1716-17. “The appearances were probably those of the Aurora borealis,” he suggests. If the urge to explain sounds familiar, note also the singer’s need to attest to the reliability of the witnesses (not to mention his anticipation of the Buchanan Brothers’ eschatological interpretation). Some things, it appears, never change.

The second-oldest UFO song was inspired by some curious events in the mid-19th Century, when a number of Nebraska residents claimed to have seen a huge lighted “serpent” shaped object flying or hovering overhead. The late Western historian Mari Sandoz, in her *Old Jules Country* (1965), quotes this fragment of an apparent folk ballad inspired by this early UFO flap:

*’Twas on a dark night in Sixty-six
When we was layin’ steel.*

*We seen a flyin’ engine come
Without no wing or wheel*

*It came a-roarin’ in the sky
With lights along the side...*

And scales like a serpent’s hide.

If any *IUR* readers know of other early songs on UFO themes, I would be happy to hear from you. ■

Mea Culpa: A Letter from the Editor-in-Chief

One can get into trouble when one does not follow one's own rules. One such rule, which I have endeavored to follow whenever possible, is to interview UFO witnesses in situ, preferably at about the same time of day or night. Not only can one then ask more relevant questions of the witnesses but obvious discrepancies can be quickly spotted.

I failed to follow this rule in the account of a UFO sighting that had come to me from Nannette Morrison, of Charlottesville, Virginia, and which was published in the November-December 1983 issue of *IUR*. As a consequence I was severely called to task by Bruce Martin, professor of chemistry at the University of Virginia, in the pages of *The Skeptical Inquirer* (Fall 1984, pp. 56-60). Martin holds that the sighting in question was merely of an airplane landing at the Charlottesville airport that evening at about that time. He says that, although Morrison stated she lives some 25 miles from the airport, in fact the distance proves to be 5.5 miles (confirmed from a scale map of Charlottesville provided me by a good friend in that city) and the nightly plane had indeed landed at about the time of her and her mother's sighting.

Unfortunately I did not follow my usual investigative procedures, not only because of lack of time and funds but also out of consideration for the fact that the primary witness was a staff member of the Neuroscience Program at the University of Virginia Medical School and had lived in the area in which her sighting occurred for some 25 years. I assumed that she not only should know how far from the airport she lives but also should be well acquainted with the scheduled passenger planes that fly in her immediate airspace. Considering these qualifications and basing my judgment on several long phone conversations with both witnesses, several letters and, finally, information from a physician friend who had visited Morrison and who had been left with a positive impression of her, I felt that a personal visit would not add significantly to the case.

It appears that I was mistaken. I should have investigated personally and I apologize for not doing so. It is apparent that Morrison was wrong about the airline distance to the airport from her house (although driving distance may be as much as 20 miles away because the area is quite hilly). Thus Martin's point—up to a point—is well taken. But when

he goes on to impugn my honesty, scientific competence and even my qualification to be a member of a major university, on the basis of this one instance, that is going a bit far, even for *Skeptical Inquirer*.

This year I shall have occasion to attend scientific meetings at the University of Virginia and I hope that Martin will be kind enough to discuss the other aspects of the case with me and Morrison. Until then I will leave the reader with a brief statement made in a letter to me from Nannette Morrison:

"The Morrison home absolutely does not lie under any landing pattern from the airport. There is one airplane which occasionally flies low near our home. But since I've lived here 25 years I've learned to recognize it as an airplane. It makes noise, it's never paced my car for several blocks, nor has it hovered over my car or our house."

And so we must let this rest until I can follow my stated rules and make a personal visit to Charlottesville this year. In the meantime I am grateful to Dr. Martin for having brought the true airline distance from the Morrison home to the airport to my attention. —J. Allen Hynek.

UFOs and IFOs:

Falcon Avenue, Springfield, Milton Keynes, Buckinghamshire MK6 3HG, England.)

Anamnesis, being evaluated by Keul (a psychiatrist), Dr. Malcolm Scott (a clinical psychologist at Luton Hospital) and Dr. Shirley McIver (a sociologist at York University), is a two-pronged investigation which runs alongside the conventional case study in all exotic cases. The witness completes both a Rorschach (ink-blot) test and a detailed Anamnesis life-profile questionnaire, which is tape-recorded for the purposes of scientific evaluation.

BUFORA is only a few months into a projected two-year evaluation study of this nature. But a pilot project on a dozen British cases and a similar number of Austrian cases has already cast up some interesting points.

Dr. Keul originally conceived of the plan in an effort to prove that a strong psychopathic element exists in the psychological make-up of these "exotic" witnesses. The results to date do not support the hypothesis. There are traces of psychopathic problems in some witnesses. But, in the main, such evidence is absent. Even in the most bizarre close encounters the witnesses appear to be psychologically normal.

By 1987 the figures may well be sufficient for realistic conclusions to be drawn. Right now they clearly are not. I shall say no more at this time. But my point is that ufologists are not unaware of the problems the UFO/IFO interface brings forth.

While I have made no attempt to discuss fully the data in the various matrices of the JR Set (laid out in *UFO Reality*), a couple of points are worth noting because they demonstrate another of the things that suggest that

all UFOs cannot be reduced to IFOs.

For instance, take cases with a physiological effect recorded by the witness. The JR Set matrix shows 28 percent of these came in cases in which electromagnetic effects were also described, giving an apparent relationship. IFO cases with physiological effects in the same matrix were very different. Only one case had both these features.

Likewise, in the chapter that discusses physical damage to a witness (e.g., effects that are not just claimed by a witness but are clearly visible afterwards), fully 92 percent of these rated as UFO-originated. And of these 75 percent involved entities and 50 percent involved UFO landings.

UFO Reality is available from the Center for UFO Studies for \$14.95 plus \$1.50 postage and handling. — The Editors. ■

BOOK REVIEW

Sky Crash: A Cosmic Conspiracy

Brenda Butler, Dot Street and Jenny Randles,
Neville Spearman, Ltd., Sudbury, England 1984.

Sky Crash seems destined to become a classic work in the UFO literature. It is, first of all, a gripping mystery story about what may come to rank as one of the most significant UFO events of all time—a reported landing, with numerous witnesses, in a forest near two adjacent American air bases on the east coast of England. *IUR* readers will know of the case from Jenny Randles' "Mystery at Rendlesham," *IUR*, November-December 1984.

It differs, however, from the standard mystery story in that it has no solution. We are left to wonder, for example, if this is really a UFO incident—or a disinformation ploy designed to cover a sensitive national-security matter having nothing to do with UFOs. If this is a UFO incident (as all the witnesses so far claim it was), what did it involve? Were informants who alleged that there was contact between the UFO occupants and the base commander telling the truth? The final few pages have no master detective (in this case three detectives) to bring together all the suspects and then, in a brilliant exhibition of masterful deduction and forensic display, solve the mystery at one stroke, leaving the readers awed and satisfied that every question has been answered.

Not that the detectives in this case didn't try. *Sky Crash* recounts the painstaking and at times crushing frustration the investigators experienced as they attempted to pry loose from the military and civilians alike the many interlocking and conflicting threads of what actually happened in Rendlesham forest just outside the Woodbridge and Bentwaters Air Force Bases.

Sky Crash should be read as a detailed progress report. In the coming months we can expect to learn more. Interest in this case has grown, on both sides of the Atlantic, and I hope that the American and British researchers will be able to work together in a spirit of true cooperation. In fact, if science is to be served and this potentially explosive mystery is to be solved, such cooperation is absolutely essential. —J. Allen Hynek

Birth Traumas

hypothesis and reject his work because of its threatening implications.

Let me say that, where I am concerned, this charge does not apply. During the past several years I have criticized the extraterrestrial hypothesis. I rejected it as an explanation for the abduction phenomenon when I put together my abduction anthology. (I had rejected it earlier on the basis of my direct research on several abduction and close-encounter cases.) If anything, I have a vested interest in finding alternative explanations not only for abduction reports but for the UFO phenomenon itself.

But despite this bias I still find Lawson's ideas utterly unconvincing. I have come to this conclusion because, in my judgment, his "findings" stem from flawed reasoning and poorly designed research. Consequently, I cannot blame other UFO researchers for rejecting Lawson's ideas either.

FOOTNOTES

1. The famous case of Betty and Barney Hill might also be cited, but the corroborating links in this case are weak. Betty's abduction experiences were first revealed to her in a series of dreams which she told to Barney before they both decided to undergo hypnosis.

2. Guided imagery is a technique whereby the subject is taken on an imaginary journey while being asked to describe what he sees and experiences. The usual session takes the subject through various natural locales such as a mountain, a river and so on.

3. It may be pertinent to note that Dr. Susan Blackmore of the University of Bristol, England, recently conducted a survey to determine whether birth imagery can explain the out-of-body experience. Birth-memory theories have often attempted to explain OBEs—an important point because some UFO percipients describe out-of-body abductions. Blackmore found no evidence that tunnel or other birth imagery is any more common in OBEs reported by persons born naturally than it is in the reports of persons of cesarean birth.

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